HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Nothing to Be Arrogant About: The Intellectual Case for Humility

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Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam **Chapter:** Perek 7 (ענוה — Humility) — Part 4 **Edition:** Feldheim **This week:** Concluding the intellectual analysis, religious arrogance, and humility before Hashem

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Recap: Chapter 7 So Far

Definition (Part 1)

- Humility = recognizing one's true status, not exaggerating it in either direction
- Internal and external humility; humility before Hashem and before people
- Humility ≠ self-debasement

The Three Methods of Training

1. **Personal/experiential** — surrounding oneself with humble people, basic practical training *(Part 1)*
2. **Through the Torah** — stories and mitzvot *(Parts 2 & 3)*
3. **Intellectual / philosophical analysis** *(Parts 3 & 4)*

Last Week (Part 3) — Method 3 Begins

Three categories analyzed:

- **Purely physical things** (food, drink, indulgence) — identical to animals; the very things that sustain us also destroy us
- **Material with metaphysical edge** (wealth, power, authority) — generate strife, jealousy, premature death (especially among kings)
- **Spiritual things — Layer 1** (intellect, prophecy) — can be lost through the smallest physical disturbance (hunger, sadness, fatigue)
- *Example:* Yaakov lost prophecy for 22 years because of his grief over Yosef
- *Example:* Even Moshe's level was limited because **כי לא יראני האדם וחי**

This Evening's Roadmap

1. **Spiritual arrogance — Layer 2:** Why the wise become more humble, not more arrogant
2. **Cosmic comparison:** The Rambam's view of celestial bodies and angels — and what this means for human pride
3. **Religious arrogance:** The most dangerous form
4. **Humility before Hashem:** The fifth bowing in Amidah and the example of David

5. **Closing principle:** Internal humility always; external humility sometimes

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PART 1 — Why the Wise Are the Most Humble

The Pattern Among the Prophets and Sages

זו היא סיבת ענוותם של הנביאים

The prophets and intellectuals stayed humble because they were **passionately seeking perfection** — and they realized that **the physical material (chomer) is the great obstacle** to reaching it.

The higher the level a person reaches, the more they realize:

- How easily it can be lost
- How fragile the connection to the heights is
- How material conditions can derail spiritual attainment in an instant

Conclusion: Those who reached the highest peaks became *more* humble, not less — because of their meditation on their own shortcomings, not their achievements.

David's Insight

הן בעוון חוללתי ובחטא יחמתני אמי

David HaMelech describes the human condition: **from our very conception we carry a tendency toward selfishness and materialism.** Every person, says Rabbi Avraham, is "stained from his seed" — born with the pull of materialism inherent in our biological origin.

The Concealed Wisdom

הן אמת חפצת בטוחות ובסתום חכמה תודיעני

Rabbi Avraham quotes **Rabbi Avraham HeChasid** (likely brother of R' Yehuda HeChasid) on this verse:

> Perfection is always coated and covered over by the material **בטוחות (covered things):**
> Whatever wisdom a person attains is hidden, fragmentary — only hints and signs, **ובסתום חכמה תודיעני:**
> never explicit — *because of the screen of material existence*

- David's response: **ולבי חלל בקרבי** — *my heart is hollow within me.* This profound recognition led to his deep humility.

The Paradox of Wisdom Producing Humility

ולכן החכמים התקיפים בדעתם עוסקים בלשמה מביאה אותם חכמתם לענווה ולא לגאווה

The wise come to humility through their wisdom — not arrogance.

How? Two-step movement:

1. They see their wisdom is **substantial relative to others**
2. But they recognize it is **trivial compared to what lies beyond**

The more you study, the more you realize how much more there is. Beginners think they know it all. True experts know how vast the unknown is.

Story — Rabbi Akiva and the Brazen Critic

A man asked Rabbi Akiva a halachic question. Rabbi Akiva didn't know the answer.

The man retorted brazenly:

אתה עקיבא בן יוסף ששמך הולך מסוף העולם ועד סופו? אשריך שזכית לשם ועדיין לא הגעת לרועה בקר! *"You are Rabbi Akiva whose name extends from one end of the world to the other? You're fortunate to have such a reputation — but you haven't even reached the level of a shepherd!"*

How would most great rabbis respond to such an insult?

Rabbi Akiva's response:

אפילו לרועה בקר לא הגעתי *"In truth, I haven't even reached the wisdom of a shepherd."*.

He didn't defend his honor. **He recognized how much more there was to know** — and so deflection became humility, not anger.

The deeper insight: Real wisdom dissolves the impulse toward arrogance, because the wise person sees the vastness of what remains unknown.

PART 2 — The Cosmic Hierarchy

This section reflects the medieval Rambam-and-Rishonim worldview that **celestial bodies possess intellect** (sentience) — a higher form of spiritual existence than humans, but lower than angels.

(Note: The Rambam states this explicitly in Mishneh Torah, Yesodei HaTorah — celestial bodies have souls, knowledge, intellect, and praise Hashem according to their level.)

The Hierarchy of Perfection

Level	Entity	Description
Highest	**Hashem**	Unattainable perfection
Malachim (angels)	Highest created beings	Pure form, no material
Celestial bodies	Spheres, stars	Higher than humans, lower than angels
Humans	—	Mixed chomer and tzura
Animals	—	Pure chomer, no tzura

The Chain of Spiritual Attainment

- The celestial bodies attain their perfection **through the angels**
- The prophets attain their perfection **through the angels and celestial bodies**
- Olam HaBa is intellectual existence **alongside the angels**

The implications: every level of human spiritual achievement is mediated through these higher levels. Therefore, comparison to them dissolves any sense of human superiority.

The Principle: Refinement of Matter → Spiritual Flourishing

כל אדם שנזדככה גשמיותו ונצטמקה חומריותו ונתעלה הוייתו תתגלה רוחניותו ויגיע לשלמות המגומרת

The more a person refines their material side, the more their spiritual side can shine. This is a major theme echoed throughout the Rishonim (Ramban, Ramchal, Rabbeinu Bachye, Nefesh HaChaim).

Conversely:

כל מי שגסה גשמיותו ונתעכרה נפשותיו דלות ואין להם מספר

The coarser the materiality, the more difficult to reach spiritual heights.

The Critical Insight: You Must Compare BOTH Ways

This is the key argument of this section. A person might say: *"True, compared to angels and celestial bodies I am nothing. But compared to other humans — to those who eat, drink, and indulge crudely — I am elevated."*

Rabbi Avraham's response: **If you're going to compare, you must compare in both directions.**

Comparing Downward (Allowed but Incomplete)

- Compared to the "Sudanese, the Berbers" (Rabbi Avraham's geographic/cultural references for very primitive societies)
- Compared to people consumed by gluttony, drink, and illicit physical pursuits
- True, you're higher

Comparing Upward (The Necessary Counterweight)

חייב לערוך את שלמותו... מול שלמות הגלגלים המתגלה דרך חומרם וצייתנותם ועבודתם

You must also compare yourself to:

- The celestial bodies — completely unaffected by hunger, fatigue, distraction
- Their constant praise (השמים מספרים כבוד אל, וצבא השמים לך משתחוים)
- Then to the **angels** — pure form with no material interference at all

Daniel's Response in Prophecy

When Daniel encountered the angels in his prophetic visions, what did he say?

איך יוכל עבד אדוני זה לדבר עם אדוני זה ואני מעתה לא יעמוד בי כוח ונשמה לא נשארה בי

"How can this servant of my lord speak with my lord? I have no strength left, no breath remains in me."

The Rambam (Yesodei HaTorah) makes the same point: meditation on the celestial bodies and angels produces love and awe of Hashem, and the person sees himself as a vessel "full of embarrassment and shame, empty and lacking."

Comparison to Hashem Himself — Total Dissolution

If you try to compare to Hashem:

- **Avraham:** אנכי עפר ואפר (I am dust and ash)
- **Iyov:** הן קלותי מה אשיבך (I am insignificant — how can I respond to You?)
- **Iyov:** והחכמה מאין תמצא — wisdom is unattainable in the land of the living

The Final Liturgical Echo

In Ne'ilah, at the peak spiritual moment of the year, we say:

הלא כל הגיבורים כאין לפניך ואנשי השם כלא היו וחכמים כבלי מדע ונבונים כבלי השכל

"All the mighty are as nothing before You, men of renown as if they never were, the wise as if without knowledge, the discerning as if without understanding."

The peak spiritual moment is precisely the moment we declare our nothingness — because the higher we rise, the clearer the comparison becomes.

Yirmiyahu's Verse — Resolved

אל יתהלל חכם בחכמתו... כי אם בזאת יתהלל המתהלל השכל וידוע אותי

"Let not the wise glory in their wisdom... only in this should one glory: in understanding and knowing Me."

The Question

Doesn't this verse permit a kind of arrogance — namely, pride in knowing God?

The Resolution

No. The Rambam (in the Moreh) explains:

- **"Glory"** here doesn't mean "be arrogant"
- It means **be joyful, fulfilled, satisfied** that you have attained the only thing worth attaining
- Furthermore: **anyone who truly attains understanding of Hashem is automatically humbled**, not made arrogant

The verse's logic: if you really reach this attainment, it produces humility — so the verse cannot be a source for arrogance. The very thing it permits glory in produces its opposite.

Closing Verse — Hashem's Concern for the World

כי אני ה' עושה חסד משפט וצדקה בארץ

Despite His incomprehensible loftiness, Hashem concerns Himself with this earth — which is **as a single point compared to the upper world.**

David: **מה אנוש כי תזכרנו ובן אדם כי תפקדנו** — *what is man that You should remember him?*

The fact that Hashem cares about us, despite our insignificance, should fill us with **extreme humility** (anavah kitzonit).

PART 3 — Religious Arrogance (CRITICAL SECTION)

This is the most practical and dangerous section of the chapter.

כשם שיש חכמים הבאים לכלל טעות ומתגאים בחכמתם... כך יש צדיקים הבאים לכלל טעות ומתגאים בדקדוק מצוותיהם

Just as the wise can fall into intellectual arrogance, the righteous can fall into religious arrogance — pride in their observance, their charity, their piety.

This is dangerous precisely because:

- It feels justified ("look how much I do for Hashem!")
- It comes wrapped in religious language
- It produces contempt for others who appear less observant

The Counter-Argument — Three Steps

Step 1: The Sheer Scope of Obligation

We are obligated to keep **all 613 mitzvot** — positive and negative. The Torah repeatedly emphasizes this:

Source	Phrase
Devarim	מי יתן והיה לבבם זה להם ליראה אותי **ולשמור את כל מצוותי כל הימים**
Eikev	בכל הדרך אשר ציוה ה' אלוקיכם אתכם תלכו
Multiple	ועשיתם את **כל** מצוותי

No picking and choosing. And consider the *level of detail* in each mitzvah. The more you study, the more you realize how many sub-obligations each mitzvah contains.

Step 2: Even Keeping 612 Falls Short

Imagine someone keeps every single mitzvah except **one** — once in their entire life. Are they "perfect"?

גם אז יהיה לוקה בחסר בשלמות הדת

No — they have failed in completeness of the religion, because they violated *some* of what Hashem commanded.

The Principle: No Cancellation in Torah

The Midrash on **אשר לא ישא פנים ולא יקח שוחד** ("Who shows no favor and takes no bribe") is interpreted as **שוחד מצוות**:

- You cannot "bribe" Hashem with mitzvot
- Doing 612 mitzvot doesn't cancel out 1 sin
- Each act has its own consequence

Step 3: Even a Single Imperceptible Sin

Even if someone hypothetically kept all 613 — could you honestly say you've never **once** transgressed:

לא תקום ולא תטור את בני עמך ואהבת לרעך כמוך

- Never carried a grudge in your heart?
- Never bore even the **feeling** of vengeance?
- Never failed in loving your fellow?

Even David HaMelech said:

כי עווני אגיד אדאג מחטאתי *"I will confess my iniquity, I worry about my sin".*

And David was testified by Hashem himself to be utterly righteous (with one famous exception).

Aside: Did David Sin with Batsheva?

כל מי שאומר דוד חטא אינו אלא טועה

The Gemara's defense of David:

Apparent Sin	Gemara's Resolution
Sending Uriah HaChiti to die	Uriah was guilty of treason and *chayav* mitah anyway. The only flaw was not convening the Sanhedrin.
Being with Batsheva (married woman)	**כל היוצא למלחמת בית דוד כותב גט כריתות לאשתו** — all soldiers in David's army wrote conditional get to their wives before war. She was therefore divorced.

This is offered here as testimony to David's overall righteousness, not as a complete defense of the episode.

Shlomo's Conclusion

כי אדם אין צדיק בארץ אשר יעשה טוב ולא יחטא

"There is no righteous person on earth who does only good and does not sin."

(Note: Rav Saadia Gaon interpreted this verse differently — that there is no one *incapable* of sinning. He held it is possible to live without sin. Rabbi Avraham follows the simple reading: **no one actually lives without sin.**)

The Mishna's converging witness: **יצר לב האדם רע מנעוריו** — *the inclination of man's heart is evil from youth.*

The Levels of Religious Observance

Rabbi Avraham distinguishes two categories of observant people:

Category 1 — External Religion (Datiut Chitzonit)

- Keeps the mitzvot externally
- Doesn't understand the inner meaning
- Doesn't have spiritual fervor connecting the action to its purpose

If you are in this category — what are you arrogant about?

The external is incomplete without the internal. You haven't yet reached the higher level of practice.

Category 2 — Internal Religion (Datiut Penimit)

- Profound spiritual fervor and meaning
- Deep connection between action and devotion
- Internalized commitment

If you are in this category — be even more cautious.

Hashem is exacting with those close to Him, even by" הקדוש ברוך הוא מדקדק עם סביביו אפילו כחוט השערה *a hair's breadth".*

The closer to Hashem, the more precise the standard. Failures that would be unnoticed in others become consequential at higher levels.

Example — Moshe and Aharon

At Mei Merivah, the sin was so subtle we can barely identify it from our position. But on their level:

יען לא האמנתם בי להקדישני *".Because you did not believe in Me to sanctify Me"*

And they were punished — not allowed to enter the Land. **The higher the position, the higher the standard.**

The Beautiful Story — The Rambam and the Self-Satisfied Mitpalel

אמרו לפניו כי אחד משומרי דת אמר בליל יום הכיפורים איני יודע על איזה עוון אחזור בתשובה

A pious person on Yom Kippur night said: *"I don't know what sin to repent for this year."*

The Rambam heard this and replied:

מסכן שכמותו... לא ידע שעליו לדעת לחזור בתשובה על החושב הוא שאין לו עוון לחזור עליו בתשובה

"How unfortunate. He needs to do teshuva for the very thought that he has nothing to do teshuva for."

The act of believing you are sin-free is itself the sin requiring teshuva. **The moment you think you've arrived, you've failed.**

CRITICAL CAVEAT — Don't Misread This

Rabbi Avraham now stops and clarifies, because this section could easily damage a healthy reader:

אין כוונתו שתראה עצמך פחות צדיק ממה שאתה באמת

"I do not mean for you to see yourself as less righteous than you actually are."

What This Section Is NOT Saying

- ❌ Walk around feeling terrible about yourself all the time
- ❌ Discount the good you've genuinely done
- ❌ Treat yourself as a rasha (cf. the Mishna in Avot: **אל תהי רשע בפני עצמך**)
- ❌ Despair of your spiritual development

What This Section IS Saying

אלא שתחשוב כי הדרגה שאתה נמצא בה נמוכה מאוד לעומת מה שהיה עליך באמת

Only at the moment of arrogance — when you feel "I am better than him, I am better than her" — pull out this analysis.

When You Feel	Then Apply
Gratitude for mitzvot you've performed	Be happy, "Baruch Hashem I was zocheh"
Awareness of growth	Recognize the genuine progress
Pride / superiority over others	**Remember failings, the scope of obligation, the levels above you**

Rav Nachman of Breslov's Parallel

אל תהי רשע בפני עצמך

Rav Nachman elaborated this extensively: do not treat yourself as wicked, because **despair is itself spiritually destructive.** Self-deflation that leads to giving up is worse than the arrogance it tries to counter.

The whole analysis is a counterweight to arrogance, not a tool for self-loathing.

PART 4 — Humility Before Hashem

הענוה לפניו יתעלה חובת כל יצור שיש בו דעה

Humility before Hashem is the obligation of every intelligent creature.

Universal Humility Before Hashem

Entity	Their Humility
Celestial bodies & angels	וצבא השמים לך משתחוים
Avraham	ואנכי עפר ואפר
David	מי אנכי? מי חיי? משפחת אבי?
Iyov	הן קלותי מה אשיבך
Moshe	מי אנכי כי אלך אל פרעה? / לא איש דברים אנכי / לא אוכל אנכי לבדי

Every great figure in Tanakh expressed deep, almost reflexive, humility before Hashem.

The Halachic Expression — Bowing in Amidah

Halacha mandates **five bowings** during prayer. Many people know the first four but miss the fifth:

#	Where	What
1	Beginning of Amidah	Baruch Atah Hashem (start of first bracha)
2	End of first bracha	מגן אברהם
3	Beginning of Modim	מודים אנחנו לך
4	End of Modim	הטוב שמך ולך נאה להודות
5	**Stepping back at the end**	**Complete prostration as you step three steps back**

The fifth one is widely missed. Many people just step back without bowing. **The Halacha (Rambam, Shulchan Aruch) is clear:** the three-step retreat should be done from a position of bowing.

The King's Posture in Prayer

ומלך ישראל היה כורע בכל התפלה מקרא ראשון עד סוף כל התפלה

The King of Israel had to remain bowed throughout the entire Amidah — from the first verse to the last.

Proof: Shlomo HaMelech

ויהי ככלות שלמה להתפלל קם מלפני מזבח אדוני מכרע על ברכיו

"When Shlomo finished praying, he rose from kneeling before the altar."

The verse implies he **rose** at the end — meaning he had been kneeling the **entire** prayer.

Why More Humility for the King?

1. **Leadership by example** — he demonstrates to the people what humility before Hashem looks like
2. **Position requires it** — his power and authority make him most at risk of arrogance, so he is given the most intensive antidote

(Note the structural parallel with the king's Sefer Torah obligation from last week — the king receives extra anti-arrogance measures *because* his position carries the most risk.)

David's Anticipation

ושחקתי לפני ה'... ונקלותי עוד מזאת והייתי שפל בעיני

"I will dance before Hashem... I will be lowlier than this and humble in my own eyes."

David anticipated and embraced this — even relishing it. The greater his position, the more eagerly he sought lowliness.

Closing Principle — Internal Always, External Sometimes

הענווה הפנימית שהזכרנו שם צריכה להתקיים בלב האדם בכל רגע ורגע

Internal humility must be present at every moment, in every situation, without exception. Nothing — not success, not position, not honors — should change it.

Like David:

ולבי חלל בקרבי / לא גבה לבי ולא רמו עיני ולא הלכתי בגדולות ובנפלאות ממני

אכן הענוה החיצונית... קרה פעמים שזה הצריך לסטות מצד הקו

External humility, however, is not absolute. Sometimes the situation requires acting *without* external humility. We will see when next week.

Summary of This Evening's Shiur

Three Major Conclusions from the Intellectual Analysis

1. **Wisdom produces humility** — the wise see how much more there is, like Rabbi Akiva refusing to defend his honor
2. **Cosmic comparison dissolves pride** — celestial bodies, angels, Hashem; if you compare, compare both ways
3. **Religious arrogance is the most dangerous form** — the scope of obligation, the impossibility of perfection, the Rambam's "teshuva on having nothing to do teshuva for"

The Critical Boundary

- The analysis is a **counterweight** to pride, not a tool for self-loathing
- When grateful for growth: celebrate it
- When feeling superior: pull out the analysis

אל תהי רשע בפני עצמך — never despair of yourself

The Two Layers of Humility

- **Internal humility:** mandatory always, in every situation
- **External humility:** sometimes (to be developed next week)

Humility Before Hashem

- Universally obligatory for all intelligent beings
- The five bowings in Amidah (don't miss the fifth)
- The king's total prostration as the ultimate model

Coming Up Next

Concluding Chapter 7 (before Shavuot):

1. **Limitations of humility** — the difference between humility and excessive self-negation
2. **Humility with other people** — practical character traits and behavior
3. **When humility is the wrong response** — situations requiring assertiveness
4. **The reward of humility** — praise and consequences

After Shavuot, we begin Chapter 8 — the longest chapter in the sefer.

B'Ezrat Hashem
